from the apex court. That it did nearly two decades after it was formulated, while a 2018 arrangement was struck down, revealed the maturity and sincerity of purpose of Ratan in making transparent and legitimate a practise that was bedevilling Indian democracy.

Ratan's commitment to societal development gained recognition both within and without the nation. Two well-known US leaders, sharing their thoughts on this, said that he does not permit his group's commercial interests hold his ethical values hostage. Kissinger said that Ratan is 'concerned not only with profits but with the evolution of his society, and he has understood that in this rapidly evolving world, the extent he can make a contribution to his society it also helps his business activities—but he doesn't do it in a primarily commercial sense'. Maurice Greenberg comments that Ratan 'wanted to see India succeed, the people live better'. He wanted to 'find ways to help different classes of Indians. I hope every country has leaders like that'.

Unbending Ethical Framework

Ratan's views on how a business should be run has integrity at its heart. He told *McKinsey Quarterly* in 2005, 'What I feel most proud of is that we [the Tata Group] have been able to grow without compromising any of the values or ethical standards that we consider important … It was a major decision to uphold these values and ethics in an environment that is deteriorating around you. If we had compromised them, we could have done much better, grown much faster, and perhaps been regarded as much more successful in the pure business sense. But we would have lost the one differentiation that this group has against others in the country. We would have been just another venal business house … And companies that are not good corporate citizens—those that don't hold to standards and that allow the environment and the community to suffer-are really criminals in today's world.'

Ratan's uprightness and his staunch belief in ethical behaviour were in evidence when Tata Steel was asked to pay a bribe for the extension of a ferro-chrome mine in an Indian state in the early 1990s, J.J. Irani recalled. The state government had recommended the proposal to the Central government. Irani met the minister in charge who was quite receptive. But as he was leaving, the minister told him: 'See my private secretary